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Staying in the game: How women CEOs build leadership that endures

What distinguishes those who achieve sustained excellence in the CEO job? In-depth conversations with leaders reveal five common principles they rely on to guide their actions.

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The CEO role tests any leader's resilience. For women, the scrutiny can be sharper, the resistance more persistent, and the margin for error thinner. The chief executive job is often described as the loneliest in business; with women still underrepresented at the very top, the scarcity of peers can make isolation more pronounced.

Seasoned women CEOs, however, have learned to meet those realities. They have crafted and lived by a set of leadership principles that strengthen their effectiveness and enable them and their organizations to thrive over time.

We have spent several years speaking with women leaders who have deep experience navigating disruption, ambiguity, political headwinds, and nonlinear career paths.[1] They have done so in predominantly male-led industries such as banking, energy, and logistics.

In a 2025 article, we examined how early-tenure CEOs in this cohort harnessed their human-centric skills to navigate the challenges and polarities of the role. Here, we look forward in leadership tenure to understand how seasoned women CEOs "stay in the game." We found that those who sustain high performance over time share a distinctive leadership architecture—a set of deeply held convictions that guide decisions, protect energy, and create durability under pressure.

"Performance and humanity can coexist," said one of the women CEOs we interviewed. "I believe we can lead differently."

In this article, we explore five leadership principles these CEOs share: grounding their actions in purpose, showing authentic courage, accepting support, seeing the system clearly, and making the job sustainable within the context of their broader lives. These principles offer insights for all leaders grappling with challenges that may not have easily discernible outcomes.

Creating an operating system: How I lead and how we work together

Leadership principles are the clear, deeply held beliefs that guide how a CEO makes decisions, especially when the path forward is uncertain. They sit between values (what we care about) and actions (what we do).

A strong leadership principle is:

— *Actionable*: it guides choices in key moments

— *Nuanced*: it clarifies trade-offs when priorities collide

— *Stable*: it holds steady across cycles, crises, and contexts

— *Specific*: it reflects the leader and the organization, not generic ideals

[1]Under an executive program attended mostly by women in North American industries such as banking, energy, infrastructure, logistics, and steelmaking, we observed and interacted with several hundred C-suite executives. We also conducted roughly a dozen in-depth interviews with women CEOs, including some who have retired and who now serve on boards, to discern patterns about how they got to the top role and thrived once there.

For CEOs and other senior leaders, these principles function as a leadership operating system; they are a recognizable way of creating value. They clarify a leader's unique edge, define how value is created beyond metrics, and become a "decision-making brand" that others can anticipate and trust. Here are five common leadership principles that emerged from our interviews.

Make decisions based on purpose, not pressure

Personal leadership principle: I exercise authority in the service of purpose, not to protect my position or prove my worth. I use my position to advance what the organization needs, even when doing so is unpopular.

"Purpose-driven decisions create clarity, reduce frustration, and fuel resilience," said the CEO of a utility. "Uniting around purpose also means anchoring decisions in long-term societal impact. In our case, that means delivering for our customers through reliability, affordability, and service."

Our group was unequivocal: The CEO role is not about the title, but the impact. "Once you're in the role, you realize you're swimming in your purpose," said the CEO of an energy company. "It stops being about the job and becomes about what only you can do."

"The title is not the right motivation," said the retired CEO of a financial services company. "You need to want to accomplish something—to have a vision and a conviction about the contribution you want to make."

When deciding whether to enter a high-stakes CEO race, she tested what motivated her. Was there a mission worth the personal and political cost? She also has declined board seats at "fantastic companies" when the people, values, or culture didn't align with her own, even when the prestige or compensation was attractive. "Don't ask, 'Is this role impressive?' Ask instead, 'Is there something here that calls me to serve?'"

How we work as a team: We optimize for enterprise impact, not for individual agendas or optics. We elevate issues based on what is right for the organization. We challenge misaligned work quickly. Once we make decisions, we align and execute them together.

Common purpose is strengthened when leaders are open and vulnerable. The utility CEO said that if you pretend to know something, people will figure that out fast. But "when you admit you don't know, it's amazing how quickly they will help you."

A defining leadership pivot occurred when she admitted that she didn't know something in an area where she had little expertise. She found that her vulnerability led to more credibility and support, and better results. "Humility is a strength, and vulnerability can be a performance accelerant," she told us.

She believes the difference between authentic and performative vulnerability is crucial to a CEO's success. For instance, she used to script her town halls and deliberately insert a "vulnerability story," believing that's what strong leaders should do. The stories were real but curated. She was crafting how her openness would land.

That was performative vulnerability: controlling disclosure to signal authenticity.

When she stopped packaging the stories and allowed herself to speak more spontaneously—admitting uncertainty and sharing reflections that felt unfinished—she was being authentically vulnerable. She had gone from managing perception to offering an unpolished openness that strengthened connection.

Purpose-driven leadership also shapes how CEOs engage stakeholders, especially in moments of uncertainty. Just days after stepping into the role, the CEO of a logistics company was urged to avoid a tense national customer conference. Service levels were down, customers were frustrated, and she had not yet fully formed a response. A CEO's instinct in such moments might be to wait to gather data, prepare the narrative, and reduce risk. But she went anyway.

"I had almost nothing to say," she recalled. "But in difficult times, the worst thing you can do is pull back." Her philosophy is simple: Call stakeholders before they call you and show up before you have all the answers. Presence, she believes, signals accountability and builds trust.

Choose courage over comfort

Personal leadership principle: I act with courage rooted in principles, not in comfort with the outcome. I make hard calls when values and evidence are clear.

Principled courage builds durable value because it improves the quality of decisions, reinforces accountability, and strengthens trust. Performative boldness, by contrast, may appear decisive in the moment, but consumes energy and weakens credibility over time. As one CEO put it: "Learn fast, ask for help, don't posture."

A global energy company CEO told us that earlier in her career she found herself misaligned with her boss on a decision she believed was fundamentally wrong—not just strategically, but in terms of values. She made her case, but he wouldn't listen. She realized that if she stayed silent and complied, she would be endorsing a direction she did not believe in. She told him that if this was the path forward, she would have to leave.

That moment of principled courage changed the dynamic. Her boss saw that she wasn't acting out of ego or stubbornness, but from conviction. He asked her to sit down and talk it through, and ultimately he revised his course of action.

The outcome was positive. But what made the moment powerful wasn't that she "won." It was that she was willing to lose.

The logistics company CEO also said something about courage that struck us as crucial. She believes leaders should run to the fire because they learn the most and become better leaders in the toughest moments. If an executive comes to her and says, "I have an activist investor and I think I'm going to leave," she counsels them to stay and deal with the situation because they won't get a better hands-on experience.

How we work as a team: We face reality immediately and act before problems become crises. We surface risks and trade-offs early, putting personal fears and interests on the table, and don't defer difficult decisions. We act on principles even when outcomes are uncertain.

One CEO made sure to frame team actions as a question: "If we were acting with courage, what would we do now?" This enabled her to create psychological safety while maintaining a rapid pace of decision-making.

Find strength through support

Personal leadership principle: I strengthen my impact by avoiding excessive self-reliance and the reflex to become the rescuer. I invest in coaches, advisers, and teams that challenge me, broaden my perspective, and help me lead with clarity.

Our CEOs believe it is essential to ask for support—and to find people you trust who see you more fully than you see yourself. One CEO practiced both an "official tour of the table and an unofficial tour," or formal meetings followed by informal conversations to discover what people really think. She continues that practice today as a board chair, creating space for dissent and recalibration. "Don't wait for the truth to come to you—go looking for it."

If success depends on the CEO personally holding everything together, the system must be redesigned. Self-reliance is what gets so many leaders to the top, but it is a less useful attribute once in the role. Scaled leadership creates durability—for both the CEO and the institution. "We get there by being self-reliant, but that becomes a trap," another CEO noted. "If you don't ask for help, eventually you burn out."

How we work as a team: We define strength as the ability to mobilize the right support at the right time. We avoid unnecessary heroics and last-minute rescues by asking for help early, building complementary teams, and making ownership explicit. This increases speed, reduces risk, and sustains high performance without an overreliance on any one individual.

At the leadership table, asking for help is often misunderstood as admitting you can't do the job. To the contrary, it's about having the courage to put your toughest, most complex issues on the table—especially when you don't yet have answers. Inviting different perspectives shows that you believe these challenges deserve collective problem solving.

Strength is not how much you can carry alone—it's how effectively you engage the system around you. Teams can ask: Who else needs to be involved so this work doesn't rest on one person? How can we bring multiple perspectives and productive dissent to inform complex decisions?

Another CEO said she likes to “build coalitions to drive stronger outcomes,” adding, “I don’t believe I know everything, so learning and improvement are disciplines I live by and I want my teams to live by.”

Own the system, not just the outcome

Personal leadership principle: I must see the system clearly, whether looking at a team or the whole organization. I expect resistance, criticism, and volatility as part of the role and I manage my inner critic deliberately. I don’t take the system personally, and I approach challenges with curiosity.

This learning mindset enables decisive leadership without ego. It creates strong authority without identity entanglement. “You’re there to serve the institution, not yourself,” said a former university president. “That mindset changes how you lead.”

One CEO described an evolution in her approach to the job when she learned not to take organizational dynamics personally. She “takes herself out of the picture” to observe the system—the incentives, positioning, and patterns at play. What once felt threatening now feels fascinating because she looks at complexity, personalities, and power dynamics more strategically. “Most of it is just noise,” she concluded.

However, under sustained pressure, disagreement can quietly morph into self-doubt, eroding confidence and creating hesitation, especially when leaders become depleted. That may be a problem that affects women more than men, in her opinion. As the former financial group CEO put it, “When doubt shows up, widen the circle, don’t shrink into yourself.”

As leaders move into the most senior roles, the nature of leadership changes, another CEO said. The challenge is no longer execution, but judgment. Decisions increasingly generate resistance—not because they are flawed, but because the stakes are higher and interests diverge. This is where many leaders, particularly women, begin to lose confidence because they mistake resistance for a signal to dilute conviction. Instead, they must maintain an unwavering focus on doing what is right for the organization, she said.

How we work as a team: We debate ideas rigorously without personalizing disagreement. We separate people from problems. We test assumptions without blame and treat challenges as a performance behavior, not a threat. We recognize that outcomes reflect the systems we design—our incentives, norms, and behaviors. By continuously strengthening how we work, we build trust, reduce friction, and drive sustainable performance together.

Owning the system sometimes means redesigning the incentives that quietly undermine performance. As one CEO examined her organization’s annual business planning process, she realized leaders were “negotiating” their targets rather than discussing what was possible. Because compensation was tied to negotiated business plans, “everyone was working their paycheck,” she said.

Instead of calling rhetorically for a more ambitious approach, she simplified the system by reducing dozens of performance measures to a small set of enterprise-wide metrics. The message was clear: We win or lose together.

The tone of conversations changed as leaders began debating potential rather than defending targets. “Truth telling isn’t a personality trait,” she noted. “It’s a system outcome.”

One CEO faced declining survey scores showing reduced employee confidence in the senior executive team. She dealt with this tension by creating a reframing exercise. She asked her team to imagine teaching a class, “How to undermine confidence as an executive team,” inviting them to define the behaviors and dynamics that would produce exactly the results they were seeing. That playful format allowed everyone to see their contribution to the problem, shifting the conversation from blame to ownership. As a result, the senior team was able to focus on changing the system they had created.

Make the job sustainable

Personal leadership principle: I design my life and my leadership so I can stay in the game, not just survive the role. I treat my energy as a strategic asset that I use to create value and invest it only where I can create real impact. I involve my family and other partners in major decisions and treat intensity as episodic, not permanent.

Our CEOs made life architecture part of their strategic decision-making, not an afterthought. They involved their families in major decisions, including relocation. The question can be reframed from whether the family can adapt to whether a new posting might be an adventure for everyone. As one put it, “Test the family system—does it support the intensity of the role?”

Instead of trying to find sustainability inside the role, these CEOs focus on designing sustainability within the context of their broader lives. They recognize that leadership is part of life, not separate from it. “I don’t like power or money enough to burn energy on the wrong fight,” said a former telecom CEO.

Making the job sustainable also requires disciplined management of time and energy. The logistics company CEO was surprised by how quickly her time ceased to feel like her own once she stepped into the role. Invitations multiplied, external visibility increased, and every meeting seemed important. “In some ways, the world opens to you,” she reflected. “But the demands are incredible.”

Early on, she said yes too often. The cost was subtle but real: fragmented focus, less recovery time, and diminished strategic clarity. Over time, she introduced a deliberate filter. She evaluated every invitation by asking two questions: *What outcome am I trying to drive?* and *What impact do I uniquely need to have?* If the connection was weak, the answer was no.

This discipline was difficult—particularly for a naturally curious leader—but she came to understand energy as a strategic asset. By aligning time with purpose, she sustained herself and clarified priorities for the enterprise.

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Treating energy as capital helps leaders with alignment, boundaries, and trade-offs, optimizing the job to ensure a sustainable life. When that doesn't happen, women may leave leadership—not because they lack stamina, but because energy is spent without impact.
"Burnout comes when you confuse exhaustion with opting out, when really what's needed is support and redesign," one CEO said.

How we work as a team: We are intentional about how we work, not just what we deliver. Most executive teams drain energy through long reporting meetings and by operating as a team of leaders rather than a true leadership team.

We focus work that only we can do together—making big-bet decisions, resolving complex interdependencies, reprioritizing resources, and engaging in deep collective learning. When executive teams concentrate on this value-creating work, meetings become energizing rather than depleting, burnout decreases, and the work becomes sustainable. Simple practices, such as tech-free meetings, sharp agendas, and clarity of purpose, reinforce the shift from energy drain to energy generation.

The women we spoke with focused on their team's psychology, building trust in both meetings and in their operating rhythm. One of our leaders summed up the stakes for CEOs and their teams well: "People don't need a perfect CEO," she said, "They need someone real they can follow."

Top-line thoughts on staying in the game

Today's leaders operate in what some describe as a "BANI" world—brittle, anxious, nonlinear, and incomprehensible. The pace of change and constant flow of information can create deep disorientation. Tools and data may increase speed and offer apparent certainty, but they can also create the illusion of clarity in a world that is complex and ethically charged. Leaders face decisions that require business acumen, ethics, and judgment, often without reliable reference points. There are no easy answers.

One experienced CEO offered advice for women earlier in their careers: Think beyond your role and expand your perspective early. Don't think only about your function, but about the whole organization. "Future CEOs think like CEOs long before they have the title."

Women CEOs, especially those operating in predominantly male-led industries, have faced difficult, high-stakes decisions for decades. For those who have served in the C-suite for a long time, crafting and living by strong leadership principles has created a virtuous cycle: The more leaders hone their principles, the more effective these ideals become. In a world that constantly competes for a CEO's attention, this combination of values, discipline, and clarity offers a way for all leaders to thrive and lead well over time.

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